Opera in Dresden before 150,000 people, marking the Allied bombing of the city in 1945. ‘Forty years ago, everything of German and world cultural value concentrated here in such an impressive and unique way was reduced to rubble and ashes in a matter of hours,’ he said. ‘The commemoration of this event marks a warning and commitment by us not to allow a third world war.’9

Throughout this period, Honecker continued to correspond with Helmut Kohl and, during the frantic pace of change in the Soviet Union, held his first one-on-one meeting with Gorbachev in May 1985 at the Kremlin – it was a stiff and distant affair, but a far cry from the prickly tension he endured with Chernenko. A far more pleasurable encounter came with Willy Brandt’s three-day visit to East Berlin in September. Unlike in 1970 – when he was portrayed as a white knight in Erfurt – Brandt’s carefully orchestrated itinerary shielded him from public view. Honecker need not have worried, the only hiccup occurred at a news conference where German journalists spared Brandt embarrassment about the Guillaume affair, but a less considerate American asked whether he had ‘pardoned Honecker’ for ‘slipping the spy’ into the Bonn Chancellery. After a deathly silence, Brandt said: ‘Ten years is a long time in politics. I can’t recall that the name you mentioned came up in our talks.’

All in all, 1985 proved an eventful year in Politburo affairs; two old-guard hardliners removed themselves; Defence Minister Heinrich Hoffmann by heart attack and Konrad Naumann – the maladroit Berlin party chief – by a supposed coup attempt which took place in two phases.

In early November, Naumann recklessly misbehaved during a surreal encounter with a group of academics from the Academy of Social Sciences while discussing plans for the 750th anniversary of Berlin. Naumann, who had a decades-long reputation for drinking, was already tipsy when he barked at the scientists: ‘Shall I tell you some facts, or do you want to hear the shit printed in Neues Deutschland?’

The remark caused a ruffle and one of the professors criticised Naumann saying: ‘You are also just working to get a black limousine.’ Sarcastically, he replied: ‘Do you drive a Trabi?’ When the academics burst out laughing, Naumann lost his self-control, launching into an obscenity-laced tirade. He